



This silver-colored metal can be polished to a bright silver-white finish.

Nugget of pure platinum refined in a laboratory

Platinum

78 Pt This precious metal is quite rare, which makes it expensive. It is used in jewelry and also plays an important role in industry as a catalyst, such as in the production of nitric acid, which is used in making fertilizers.

Jewelry

As a beautiful, durable, and lustrous white metal, platinum has been used for making jewelry for centuries. It has a high resistance to corrosion, meaning that it stays shiny for a long time.



Platinum ring

Rutherfordium

104 Rf An artificial element, rutherfordium is made by bombarding californium atoms with carbon atoms, and only a few atoms of it have ever been produced. It was first created in the 1960s, but due to controversy over the results, it wasn't formally named until 1996.

Naming rutherfordium

Element number 104 is named in honor of the New Zealand chemist Ernest Rutherford. He was one of the first scientists to conduct experiments that helped explain the structure of the atom. His "Gold Foil Experiment" determined that the atom had a dense nucleus.



Caricature of Ernest Rutherford

Mercury

80 Hg People have been using this element for thousands of years. Around 10,000 years ago, the mercury-containing mineral cinnabar was used to make wall paintings in Çatalhöyük in modern-day Turkey. Pure mercury—sometimes called "quicksilver"—is the only metal that is liquid at room temperature.



Cinnabar

Striking, deep-red mineral

Cinnabar

As the main ore of mercury, cinnabar has been used for thousands of years. In 16th-century China, craftspeople painted wooden jewelry boxes with the bright red pigment extracted from cinnabar. This mineral was also once crushed into a powdered form for use as a cosmetic. Over the centuries, its use has declined due to mercury's toxicity.

Mercury thermometer

Polish-born Dutch physicist Daniel Gabriel Fahrenheit invented the mercury thermometer in 1714. His name is given to the Fahrenheit temperature scale that is still used in the US. In a mercury thermometer, the mercury expands and rises up the narrow tube as the temperature increases. Because of concerns over mercury's toxicity, these thermometers are being gradually replaced by safe, digital versions.



Dense, silver-white liquid at room temperature

